Nasser and the non-aligned world

As we have seen, Nasser was determined that Egypt should not be drawn into any alliance with the West (or, for that matter, with the Soviet Union). He wanted the Arabs to be neutral and to defend themselves. This neutralist stand won Nasser many admirers beyond the Arab world. The leaders of major countries like India and China admired his independent stance and treated him as an equal. These countries were, like Egypt, determined not to be drawn in to any alliance either with the West or with the Soviet Union. They wanted to keep out of the Cold War and remain **non-aligned**. In 1955, Nasser attended the first conference, in Indonesia, of these non-aligned states. His international prestige grew and he came to be seen as the leader of the whole Arab world.

Key term

Non-aligned
The non-aligned nations were those that did not wish to step into line with either the West (the USA and its allies) or with the Soviet Union and its allies.

Nasser and the Suez crisis 1956

Three further events were to accelerate the onward march of Arab nationalism. The first was the so-called Czech arms deal. The second was the Suez crisis of 1956 and the third was the merging of the states of Egypt and Syria in 1958.

Key question
What was the importance of the Czech arms deal in the growth of Arab nationalism?

The Czech arms deal, September 1955

In September 1955, Nasser announced that he had agreed to buy arms from the Czech government. In return for sales of cotton and rice, Egypt was to be supplied with weapons, including Soviet aircraft and tanks. This was Nasser showing his 'independent' stance which so worried the West. A few months earlier, Israeli armed forces had attacked Egyptian military headquarters in Gaza and killed 35 Egyptian troops. Now, at last, Nasser had secured the weapons Egypt needed to defend itself. The announcement of the Czech arms deal had an electrifying effect, not just in Egypt but in many other Arab countries. On the streets of the Arab cities of Damascus, Amman and Baghdad there was rejoicing. Nasser was seen as a saviour, throwing off the domination of the West and securing the defence of the Arab world. Now at last, the Arabs had achieved their victory over 'imperialism' and its 'illegitimate offspring', Israel.

Key dates

Nasser announced Czech arms deal: 1955

Suez crisis: 1956

The Suez crisis, 1956

There was similar euphoria in the Arab world a year later, in 1956, when Britain and France were forced to withdraw from Egypt after attempting to regain control of the Suez Canal. This episode is explained fully on pages 41–4. For a short time, it looked to the Egyptian government as if Cairo might be attacked by Anglo-French forces and Nasser decided to take poison rather than suffer the humiliation of being captured, but then came news that Britain and France were to call off their military action.

Nasser himself recognised that he had been saved by American intervention but, on the radio and throughout the Arab world, it was Egyptian resistance that was portrayed as having won the day. Arab cities erupted in anti-Western demonstrations and riots,